The PRC was become radicalized as Peking launched attacks against Moscow and against any communist movements that they considered “reactionary.” The Chinese branded the Revolutionary Council reactionary, and Beijing even labeled Ne Win as a Chiang Kai-shek of Burma. The ouster of pro-PRC Aung Gyi as a key policymaker in Burma put an additional strain on the relationship. With the onset of the Cultural Revolution in China, the Burma-China rift widened.

Internally, the Burmese Communist Party (BCP) was split along a Moscow-Peking divide. The BCP under Than Tun followed a Maoist model and took base in Pegu Hills. Burmese Red Guard units were established. Harsh reprisals against anyone suspected of having sympathy toward Moscow were implemented. Mass trials and purges of what was labeled “Moscow returnees” took place. Most disturbing, Buddhist temples were targeted and monks were assassinated. This extremism led to an implosion of the BCP.

Within Burma, the Chinese community had their own schools, and most were loyal to the PRC government. Many within the community showed support for Mao and the Cultural Revolution. When the Burmese economy started to decline, the Chinese became a convenient target for the disgruntled unemployed youth in Burma. Riots occurred and Chinese businesses were looted and burned. The Burmese authorities allowed this communal violence to occur so that the focus would be removed from the failing policies of the Revolutionary Council.

At the peak of this altercation, China launched an incursion into Burmese territory, attacking a garrison at Mongko. Initially the Chinese forces were successful, as 3,000 miles of territory was seized by the summer of 1968. Ne Win now turned to both Moscow and Washington for help. A limited amount of assistance came from the United States in the form of weapons and equipment and some training for air force pilots. The USSR sent in an advisory team and discussion of aid accelerated.

The Burmese military quickly rebounded. First they dealt with the internal problem of the BCP. The BCP forces were isolated and could not get needed aid and supplies. Ne Win's forces assassinated the party chairman Thakin Than and the BCP base was overrun within days. As the Cultural Revolution died down, support for the incursion into Burma